THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

One Soul, Five Powers: Know Yourself Before You Heal

The Rambam's Eight Chapters, Chapter 1

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** The Introduction and Chapter 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 30 January 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The Rambam and where the Eight Chapters come from

The Rabbi opened the new series by calling the Shemonah Perakim the foundation for understanding the Rambam's whole philosophy, and for any philosophical work within Torah.

The Rambam, Rabbi Moshe ben Maimon, was born in Cordoba in 1135 and spent most of his life in Fustat, near Cairo, where he died in 1204. In his lifetime many attacked his writings as un-Jewish, and some accused him of wanting the Mishneh Torah to replace the Talmud. By the 1300s his greatness was recognised everywhere. One theme runs through his life: the wish to harmonise Torah, Talmud and the beliefs of our faith with Aristotelian philosophy. He called Aristotle the chief of the philosophers.

His three great works are: - **The Mishneh Torah** (the Yad HaHazakah, fourteen books), his summary of the whole Talmud. The Rabbi noted that at least two thirds of the Shulhan Arukh quotes the Rambam directly. - **The Moreh Nevuchim**, the Guide for the Perplexed, his great work of philosophy, which influenced thinkers well beyond the Jewish world. - **The Commentary on the Mishnah** (Perush HaMishnayot), his first work, written in Arabic between the ages of about 23 and 33 while he wandered in exile without all the books he needed.

When the Rambam reached Masekhet Avot in that commentary, he felt he needed to write an introduction. That introduction is the Eight Chapters, printed before Avot in any edition of the Mishnah that carries his commentary.

The Rambam's introduction: easy to learn, hard to live

Avot looks simple. It is the classic Shabbat afternoon shiur: pleasant, ethical and practical. The Rambam gives two reasons for writing at length: 1. It is easy to study Avot but hard to put it into practice. 2. Not everything in it is as clear as it seems.

He also explains why Avot matters so much. Hazal said that whoever wants to be a hasid, a pious person, should fulfil the words of Avot. Not just study them, the Rabbi stressed, but fulfil them. Hasidut leads towards ruah hakodesh and towards nevuah, prophecy. So working on our character is the path to perfection.

Then comes a famous statement. The Rambam says that most of what follows is not his own. He gathered it from the words of Hazal and also from philosophers, ancient and recent. He will not say who said what, for two reasons: it would make the work long, and a reader might dismiss an idea once he hears it came from someone he does not like. "Listen to the truth from whoever says it."

The Rabbi drew a lesson from this. We all carry prejudices, often without knowing it. The Rambam removes the names so that we judge each idea by whether it is true. Anyone who knows his philosophy can still tell which parts come from Aristotle and which from Hazal.

Why we must know the soul

Chapter 1 is about the nature of the human soul. The Rambam's reason is medical. A good doctor cannot treat one organ without understanding the whole body. In the same way, a "healer of souls" cannot help us refine our character unless we first understand the soul as a whole and its parts. As the Rabbi put it, in this chapter the Rambam is "introducing us to ourselves."

He made an important distinction of terms. The soul here is the **nefesh**, not the **neshamah**, which is a different, more spiritual discussion. The nefesh is simply what makes us alive, what "makes us tick." When a person dies, the body remains but the nefesh is gone.

He also noted that the chapter speaks about human beings as a whole, in contrast to animals. There is no distinction here between Jews and non-Jews.

One soul, not many

Some philosophers and physicians thought a person has several souls. The Rambam cites the chief of the physicians, whom the Rabbi identified as Hippocrates, who spoke of three souls: natural, vital and psychic. The Rambam rejects this. There is **one** soul with different powers or faculties. When philosophers speak of "parts" of the soul, they do not mean parts like the limbs of a body that can be separated. The soul is not divisible.

The five faculties

The Rambam lists five faculties, from the most physical to the least:

1. **Nutrition (hazan).** The Rambam lists seven powers here: attracting nourishment, retaining it, digesting it, expelling waste, growth, reproduction, and separating the body's fluids. The Rabbi included breathing and circulation in this picture and said the details belong to medicine, a field the Rambam also wrote on.
2. **The senses (margish).** Sight, hearing, taste, smell and touch. Touch is unusual because it covers the whole body, while the other four are located in one place.
3. **Imagination (medammeh).** The power to hold images of things no longer in front of us and to combine them into new pictures, even impossible ones: a ship flying in the air, a man with his head in the heavens and his feet on the earth, an animal with a thousand eyes.
4. **The emotional or appetitive faculty (mitorer).** Desire and aversion, wanting and running away: anger and goodwill, fear and courage, cruelty and compassion, love and hatred. The

limbs carry these out. If we fear fire, the hand pulls away; if we want something, the legs run to it.

5. **The rational faculty (sikhli).** The power to think, acquire wisdom and tell good from bad. The Rambam divides it in two. One part is practical: crafts, agriculture, carpentry, medicine and navigation. The other is theoretical: pure knowledge with no immediate practical use. The Rabbi's example was Einstein working on relativity.

Shared with animals, but not the same

Animals plainly have nutrition and senses. So does a horse share part of our soul? The Rambam says no. The human is nourished by the nutritive power of the human soul, the donkey by that of the donkey's soul, the eagle by that of the eagle's. We use one word for all of them, but they are different things.

His analogy: three dark places are lit, one by the sun, one by the moon and one by a candle. The light may even look identical, but each comes from a different source. Only the word "light" is shared. The Rabbi said this is a mistake many philosophers made, and it leads to wrong conclusions.

The Mutakallimun and the impossible

The Rambam criticises those who held that one can only imagine what is possible. The Hebrew translation calls them "hamedabberim", the speakers. The Rabbi explained that this is a poor rendering of the Arabic: the Rambam wrote the commentary in Arabic, and Ibn Tibbon translated it into Hebrew later. The Arabic refers to the Mutakallimun, early Muslim thinkers of the *kalam* who tried to harmonise their scripture with Aristotelian philosophy. They divided things into the necessary, the possible and the impossible, and said imagination only reaches the possible. The Rambam says this is wrong: we can imagine even the impossible. The Rabbi added that this is why one should always study a text with its original language in mind.

Matter without form

The chapter ends by saying that a person who lives only with the first four faculties, without developing the fifth, is like *homer*, matter, without *surah*, form. The Rabbi linked this to King David's word in Tehillim, *golmi*: a golem is something unfinished, raw material that never received its form. Our intellect is what gives our life its form.

Summary

- The Eight Chapters are the Rambam's introduction to Avot, written because Avot is easy to learn but hard to live.
- He gathered his ideas from Hazal and the philosophers and left out names, so that we accept truth from whoever says it.
- We have one soul with five faculties: nutrition, the senses, imagination, the emotions and the intellect, which is practical or theoretical.
- Faculties we share with animals carry the same name but come from a different kind of soul, like light from the sun, the moon or a candle.

- Knowing ourselves comes first; healing the soul begins in the chapters that follow.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/4NnuBNPN4EM · More shiurim: rabbikada.com